



Contemporary Pakistan

Issues, Challenges & Prospects

State of Human Rights within the Framework of the Constitution: Minority Rights, Women's Rights & Gender Equality, and the Achievements of Pakistani Women

COURSE MODULE

Pakistan Studies

Curriculum | Credit Hours: **02**

Academic Session **2026 – 2027**

INSTITUTE

Institute of Emerging Technologies

Sukkur IBA University

Khairpur Campus

LECTURER

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SUKKUR IBA UNIVERSITY

Empowering Futures through Education

Learning Objectives

PAK-201

By the end of this lecture, students will be able to critically analyse the contemporary human-rights landscape of Pakistan within its constitutional framework, with a focused inquiry into minority protections, gender equality, and the documented achievements of Pakistani women.

01

Constitutional Literacy

Identify and interpret the fundamental rights provisions of the Constitution of Pakistan, 1973, especially Articles 20–25 and 36–40.

02

Minority Rights

Examine the legal and socio-political status of religious minorities in Pakistan and the contemporary challenges they face.

03

Women's Rights

Analyse the constitutional safeguards, statutory protections, and structural challenges facing Pakistani women.

04

Women's Achievements

Recognise the documented contributions of Pakistani women in politics, law, science, sports, literature, and civil society.

05

Critical Analysis

Develop an evidence-based, neutral perspective on the gap between constitutional text and lived reality in modern Pakistan.

PEDAGOGICAL GOAL

Civic Awareness & Evidence-Based Reasoning

Apply constitutional, historical, and sociological evidence to assess contemporary issues.

Introduction — Pakistan in the Contemporary Era

— FRAMING THE INQUIRY

A Federal Republic at the Crossroads of Tradition and Modernity

CONSTITUTIONAL PREAMBLE

"Whereas sovereignty over the entire Universe belongs to Almighty Allah alone... wherein the State shall exercise its powers and authority through the chosen representatives of the people...wherein adequate provision shall be made for the minorities to profess and practise their religions..."

— Constitution of Pakistan, 1973 (Preamble, as amended)

PAKISTAN AT A GLANCE

- Federal parliamentary republic since 1947; Constitution adopted 14 August 1973
- Population over **240 million** (6th most populous globally)
- Plural yet majority-Muslim society — minorities constitute roughly **3–4%**
- 4 provinces + AJK, GB, ICT & newly merged tribal districts
- Active member of the UN, OIC & SCO

SCOPE OF THIS LECTURE

This module examines **Part II (Articles 8–28)** of the Constitution — Fundamental Rights — alongside statutory protections and lived realities for ethnic, religious, and gender minorities. We focus on three intersecting domains: **constitutional guarantees, structural gaps in implementation, and the documented achievements of Pakistani women** as evidence of progressive trajectory.

Historical Background & Context

— A SEVEN-DECADE TRAJECTORY

From Independence to the Post-2018 Reform Era

1947 · Partition & Independence

Founding of Pakistan as a homeland for the Muslims of South Asia; the Objective Resolution precedes the constitutional text.

1956 · First Republic & Constitution

Islamic Republic declared; fundamental rights enumerated; minorities formally recognised in early legislative framework.

1973 · The Current Constitution

Parliamentary form restored; Article 25 expressly prohibits discrimination "on the basis of sex alone"; minorities protected.

2010 · 18th Amendment

Concurrent legislative list abolished; provinces gain autonomy over human-rights portfolio; ministries devolved to provinces.

2011 · Women's Protection Act / Acid Crime Act

Reforms to Hudood Ordinances; acid-crime legislation passed; women's parliamentary caucus institutionalised.

2018 → · Present Era

Transgender Persons Act 2018; rights of persons with disabilities law 2020; Digital Rights Act under consultation.

FROM IDEA TO REPUBLIC

Evolution of Rights Discourse in Pakistan

● 1940:

Lahore Resolution — political demand precedes rights enumeration.

● 1973:

Equal citizenship, religious freedom, & reserved seats institutionalised.

● Zia era (1977–88):

Islamisation policies; Hudood Ordinances expand; rights of women & minorities contested.

● 2000s–2010s:

Civil-society mobilisation; women's parliamentary caucus; NCHR (2012) & provincial HRCMs.

● 2018 →

Transgender Persons Act; PWD rights; digital rights framework under consultation.

Pakistan's rights trajectory reflects a recurring tension between textual guarantees, political will, and societal practice. Civil-society organisations (HRCP, AGHS, NCHR, NCSW) have played a critical role in keeping these questions alive in the public sphere.

Constitutional Framework for Human Rights

MAIN CONCEPT ONE

The Constitution as the Supreme Source of Rights

The Constitution of Pakistan, 1973 enshrines a comprehensive bill of rights in Part II (Articles 8–28). These provisions are enforceable directly through the High Courts under Article 199 and the Supreme Court under Article 184(3).

Article 8 · Fundamental Rights

Laws Inconsistent With Fundamental Rights

Any law, custom or usage having the force of law that is inconsistent with Fundamental Rights shall be void.

Article 25 · Equality of Citizens

Non-Discrimination on Sex Alone

"All citizens are equal before law and are entitled to equal protection of law." Nothing shall prevent special provisions for women & children.

Article 20 · Religious Freedom

Freedom to Profess Religion

Every citizen shall have the right to profess, practice and propagate his religion, subject to law, public order and morality.

Article 33 · Directive Principles

Duty to Protect Minorities

The State shall discourage parochial, racial, tribal, sectarian and provincial prejudices and protect legitimate interests of minorities.

Article 36 · Minority Protection

Safeguards for Minorities

The State shall safeguard the legitimate rights and interests of minorities, including their due representation in the Federal and Provincial services.

Article 37(e) · Welfare State

Elimination of Social Injustice

The State shall promote with special care the educational and economic interests of people in weaker or special conditions — expressly including women and children.

ENFORCEMENT PATHWAY

High Court (Art. 199) → Supreme Court (Art. 184(3)) → Federal/Provincial Human Rights Commissions → National Commission on the Status of Women (NCSW) → National Commission for Minorities (2018, proposed)

Fundamental Rights & Enforcement Mechanisms

CONSTITUTIONAL TEXT — ARTICLE-LEVEL GUARANTEES

- **Art. 9:** Security of person — life & liberty protected by law.
- **Art. 14:** Inviolability of dignity of man — slavery & forced labour prohibited.
- **Art. 19:** Freedom of speech, assembly & association.
- **Art. 25A (18th Amend.):** Free & compulsory education for ages 5–16.
- **Art. 25 (clause 2):** No discrimination on basis of sex alone.
- **Art. 26:** Non-discrimination on basis of race, religion, caste, sex, residence.
- **Art. 27:** Safeguard against discrimination in public service appointments.

ENFORCEMENT MECHANISMS

From Text to Accountability

1. **Supreme Court** — Public Interest Litigation under Art. 184(3) has shaped jurisprudence on enforced disappearances, bonded labour, & minority rights.
2. **High Courts** — Article 199 writ jurisdiction; most-affected forum for rights litigation.
3. **Federal Shariat Court** — Reviews conformity with Islamic injunctions (Art. 203-D).
4. **National Commission on the Status of Women (NCSW)** — Established 2000.
5. **National Commission for Human Rights (NCHR)** — Established 2012; 'A' status accreditation (2017, re-affirmed 2023).

CRITICAL INSIGHT

"A constitution is only as strong as its enforcement."

The Pakistani Constitution is among the most rights-enumerated in South Asia; however, scholars (Lau, 2003; Khan, 2014) note a persistent **implementation gap** — constitutional aspirations meet institutional inertia, provincial capacity limits, and political-judicial contests. Effective enforcement requires **judicial independence, statutory backing, and an active civil society** — three pillars that have grown unevenly across the federation.

Minority Rights — Framework & Profile

MAIN CONCEPT TWO

Religious & Ethnic Minorities in Pakistan — A Defined Citizenry

Religious minorities in Pakistan constitute roughly **3.5–4%** of the population, representing the following communities

- **Christians · Hindus · Sikhs · Buddhists · Ahmadis · Parsis/Zoroastrians · Bahá'ís · Kalash · Kailash Hindus · Burusho**
- Linguistic minorities (Sindhi, Baloch, Pashtun, Punjabi sub-groups, Brahui)

CONSTITUTIONAL FRAMEWORK

Rights & Reserved Representation

- **Article 20:** Freedom to profess, practise & propagate religion subject to law & public order.
- **Article 36:** State shall safeguard legitimate rights/interests; due representation in services.
- **Article 51(2A):** 10 reserved National Assembly seats for minorities on a population basis.
- **Article 106:** Reserved provincial assembly seats for minorities.
- **5% Quota:** Federal public-service job reservation for minorities.

Sources: Constitution of Pakistan, 1973 (amended); Federal Public Service Commission rules.

INDICATIVE DEMOGRAPHIC PROFILE

Population by Community (Punjab & Sindh epicentres)

Community	Approx. share
Muslims	~96%
Christians	~1.6%
Hindus	~1.3%
Ahmadis	~0.7–1%
Sikhs / Buddhists / Parsis / Bahá'ís / Others	~0.2–0.5%

Note: Aggregated ethnic/religious categorisations in national census remain contested; scholars urge disaggregated, methodology-validated counts (Gazdar, 2019; Bouatta & Gayer, 2020).

Contemporary Challenges Faced by Minorities

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

A Continuum from Symbolic Inclusion to Structural Vulnerability

01

Blasphemy Laws (PPC 295-B/C)

Disproportionately invoked against minorities; long pre-trial detention; reports of mob-instigated violence.

02

Forced Conversions

Documented cases — chiefly Hindu & Christian girls; movement for provincial legislation (Sindh Criminal Law Bill, 2023).

03

Waqf & Property Encroachments

Disputed takeovers of historic temples, gurdwaras & graveyards; legislative remedy sought by civil society.

04

Quotas in Education

College/university placements intended but unevenly implemented across provinces (Gazdar & Mallah, 2013).

05

Hate Speech & Media

Online virality documented in NCHR & HRCP reports (2017–2023); Pakistan's first Digital Rights Act in consultation.

06

Under-Representation

Reserved seats rarely translate into substantive policy influence; limited ministerial portfolios over decades.

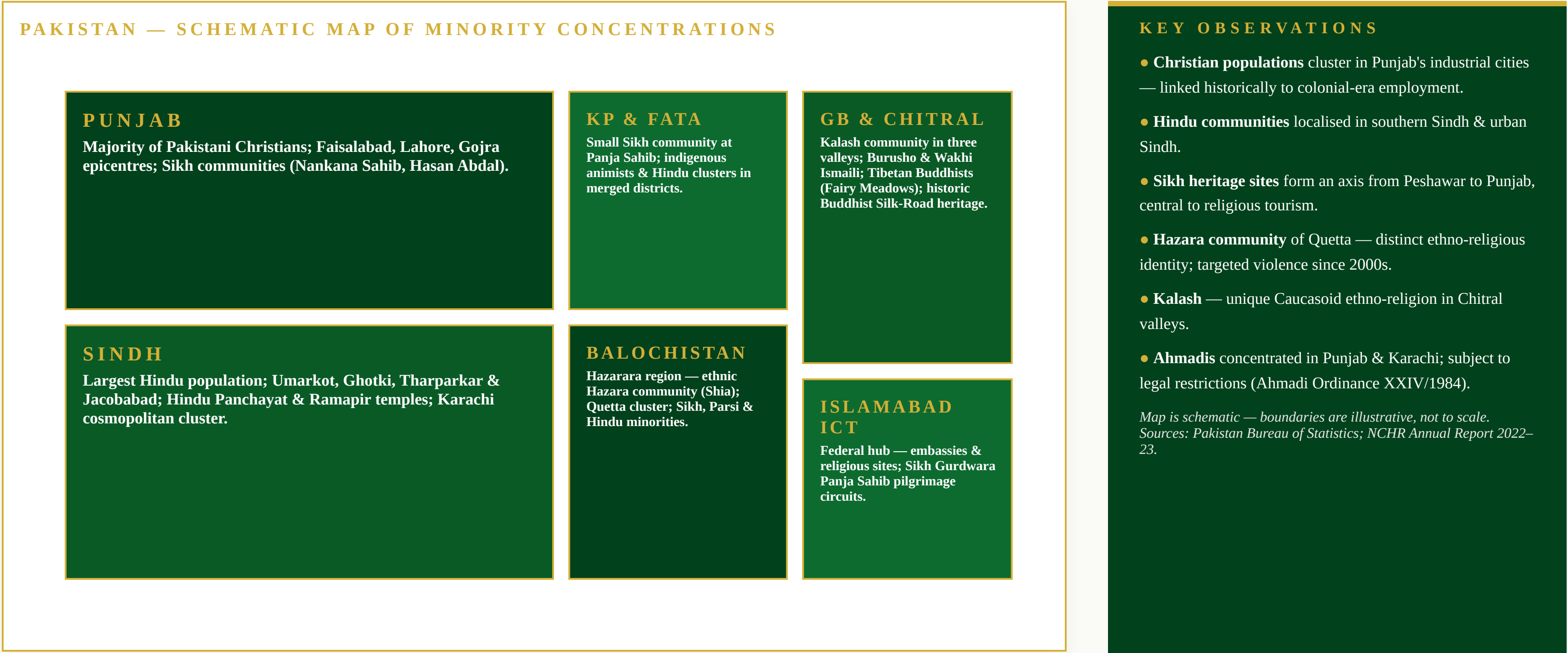
NOTABLE LEGISLATIVE & JUDICIAL STRIDES

- **Supreme Court (2014) — Faisalabad Minara-Saba case:** Ordered state to construct protective walls around religious sites.
- **Sindh Hindu Marriage Act (2018) & amendments (2023):** Mandatory registration of marriage & protection of underage weddings.
- **Sindh Criminal Law (Protection of Minorities) Act (2023):** Innovative protective framework.

Geographic Distribution of Religious Minorities

VISUAL — PROVINCIAL CLUSTER MAP

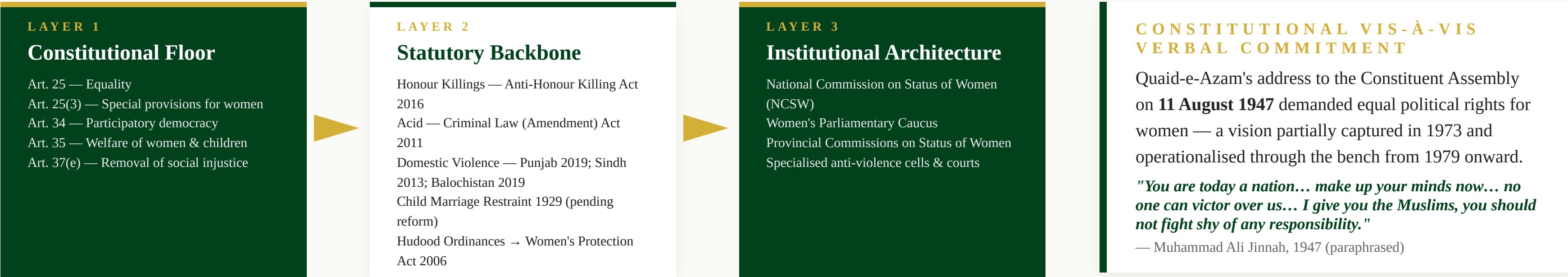
Communities Concentrated by Region & Historical Settlement



Women's Rights & Gender — Constitutional & Statutory Framework

MAIN CONCEPT THREE

From Constitutional Equality to Gender-Responsive Legislation



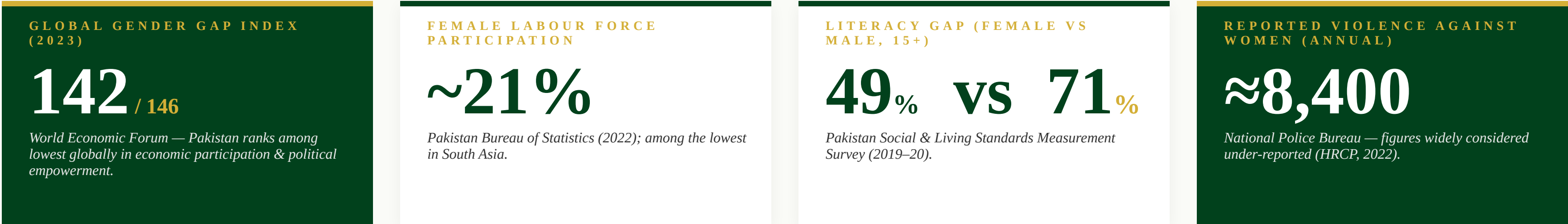
SELECTED LEGISLATIVE MILESTONES

Year	Instrument	Significance
1961	Muslim Family Laws Ordinance	Curb polygamy; regulate marriage; family arbitration councils
2006	Women's Protection Act	Transferred zina-bil-jabr to PPC; removed from Hudood
2011	Criminal Law (Amendment) Act	Acid-attack crime with mandatory minimum sentence
2016	Anti-Honour Killing Act	Prevents family pardon (qisas) in honour-killings
2018	Transgender Persons (Protection) Act	Legal recognition of third gender & protection
2022	ICT Domestic Violence Act	Federal law closer to provincial provisions

Gender Equality — Persistent Challenges

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

The Implementation Deficit — Where Constitutional Aspiration Meets Social Reality



ENDURING STRUCTURAL CHALLENGES

1. Gender-Based Violence (GBV)

Domestic violence incidents, honour-related violence, & under-reporting of psychological abuse remain acute. Helplines (e.g., 1043 in Punjab) under-resourced (Mohanty, 2016).

3. Education Pipeline Drop-off

Female enrolment rises to primary level but falls sharply at secondary & tertiary. ASER Pakistan (2023) reflects widened gender gap post-pandemic.

5. Digital & Cyber Harassment

Pakistan ranks among the top countries globally for gendered cyber-harassment complaints (Digital Rights Foundation Monitor, 2022). The Prevention of Electronic Crimes Act (PECA, 2016) — partially remedial — is widely critiqued for over-broad provisions.

2. Child & Forced Marriage

Reporting by UNFPA (2022) suggests ~18% of women aged 20–24 married before 18 — though under-registration likely; Child Marriage Restraint Bill pending reform.

4. Political & Economic Representation

Reserved seats for women in assemblies — but women elected on general seats remain rare; fewer than 5% of legislators historically (Ibrahim & Muhammad, 2021).

Pakistani Women & Their Achievements

MAIN CONCEPT FOUR

A Seven-Decade Trajectory of Civic, Scholarly & Artistic Excellence

POLITICS & STATESMANSHIP

Madam-e-Pakistan & Beyond

Shaheed-e-Milat **Fatima Jinnah** (1893–1967), Pakistan's first female dental surgeon & politician. Begum **Ra'ana Liaquat Ali Khan**, forerunner of women's parliamentary caucus.

LAW & JUDICIARY

Pioneering Jurists

Justice **Nasira Iqbal** — early SC advocate; Justice **Majida Rizvi** – first female High Court judge (1974); Justice **Ayesha Malik** (2022) - first female SC judge.

SCIENCE & MEDICINE

Nobel Laureates & Beyond

Dr. Abdus Salam (Nobel 1979) — physics (illustrative of early scientific excellence); **Dr. Azra Fazal Pechuho**, surgical oncologist & senator.

SPORTS & ATHLETICS

Cricket & Squash Pioneers

Sana Mir – former Pakistan women's cricket captain; **Maria Toorpakai** — WSF-ranked squash player from KP tribal region.

LITERATURE & ARTS

Voices that Reshaped Canon

Bano Qudsia — Aangan Khidki (1967) & Raja Gidh; **Fahmida Riaz**; **Sara Shagufta**; **Umera Ahmed**.

CIVIL SOCIETY & HUMAN RIGHTS

Human-Rights Defenders

Asma Jahangir (1952–2018) — HRCP & AGHS; UN Special Rapporteur; **Hina Jilani** — AGHS Legal Aid Cell; Aurat March organisers 2018 → .

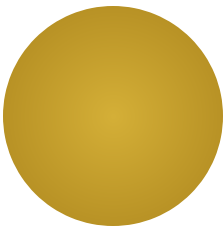
A SYNTHESIS

Across politics, law, science, sport, literature & activism, Pakistani women have continually expanded the civic space — both within constitutional channels and through civil-society pressure. Their documented trajectories complement the textual guarantees in Part II of the Constitution and reveal, in many cases, **a substantive record that long predates formal legal reform**. Educational, political and corporate spheres remain, however, the principal sites where unrealised potential concentrates.

Notable Personalities & Contributors

KEY PERSONALITIES

Architects of Pakistan's Human-Rights & Women's Movements

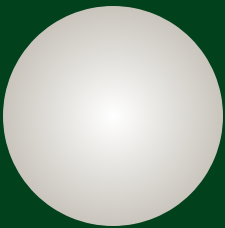


1893–1967

Fatima Jinnah

"Mother of the Nation"

First dental surgeon; co-founder & stateswoman; opposed martial law.

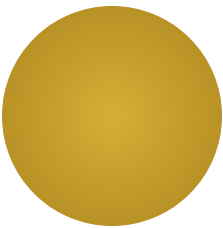


1952–2018

Asma Jahangir

UN Special Rapporteur

HRCP founder; AGHS; defended minorities, women & bonded labour.

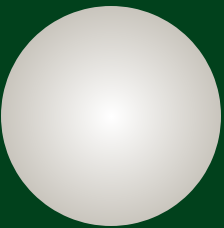


1953 →

Hina Jilani

Lawyer & Activist

AGHS Legal Aid Cell; UN SR on HRDs; pioneering pro-bono networks.

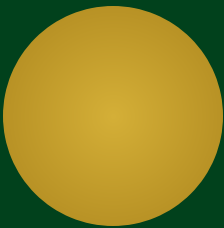


B. 1972

Justice Ayesha Malik

Supreme Court of Pakistan

First woman elevated to the Supreme Court (2022); commercial & constitutional law.

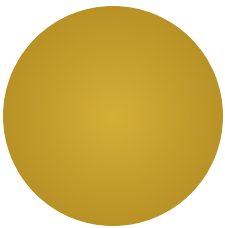


1928–2017

Bano Qudsia

Aangan Khidki Author

Pioneering feminist literature; Aangan Khidki (1967), Raja Gidh (1981).

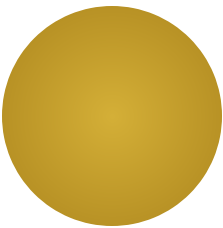


B. 1982

Sana Mir

Cricket Captain

Pakistan women's cricket captain (2009–17); Wisden Cricketer 2018.

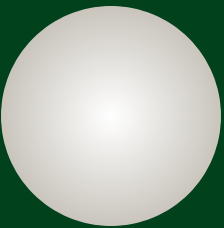


B. 1929

Begum Ra'ana Liaquat

Stateswoman

Founded All-Pakistan Women's Association (APWA) 1949; ambassador.



B. 1953

Maria Toorpakai

Squash Champion

Trailblazer from Waziristan; WSF-ranked player; gender equity symbol.

Key Events & Legislative Timeline

IMPORTANT EVENTS

Eight Decades of Constitutional, Statutory & Social Reform



Case Study — Honour & Judicial Response

CASE STUDY

Honour Killings — A Constitutional & Sociological Reading

DEFINING THE ISSUE

Honour-related Violence in Pakistan

Honour killings are murders — predominantly of women — committed by family or community members to defend perceived familial "honour". The practice intersects with custom, tribal jirgas, & the qisas/diyat legal regime.

- HRCP 2022 report: ~460 honour-killings annually documented.
- Historically, perpetrators were granted legal pardon via family blood-money compromise.
- Sindh, Punjab & Khyber Pakhtunkhwa account for most caseloads (HRCP, 2022).

LEGISLATIVE PIVOT — ANTI-HONOUR KILLING ACT 2016

Closing the Family-Pardon Loophole

Amends PPC Section 299 and CPA Section 338 by removing the heirs' authority to forgive the accused when the qisas victim is a woman or a child. Sentencing: minimum 25 years; non-compoundable; no forgiveness in cases of female victims.

Federal anti-honour killing legislation drafted with input from AGHS, HRCP, NCSW & Zindagi Trust (2014–15).

JUDICIAL RESPONSE & LIMITS

- Superior Courts increasingly invoke Art. 9 & 14 (security of person, dignity) to override familial & tribal compromises.
- PMA 1961 & harassment safeguards at the workplace are combined with anti-qisas reforms in cases of female victims.
- Provincial compliance gaps documented (Bukhari & Niazi, 2020). Implementation remains uneven.

Critical Analysis

CRITICAL ANALYSIS

Tensions Between Text, Politics, & Lived Realities

TENSION 1

Universalism vs. Religious Specificity

Preamble invokes Allah's sovereignty; Part II entitles every Pakistani to constitutional rights. This dual foundation is a source of both **moral–legal coherence** & ongoing political contestation.

Kennedy (2004); Rehman (2020).

TENSION 2

Federalism vs. National Uniformity

Post-2010 devolution empowered provincial human-rights commissions; uneven enforcement & policy variation across federation — both an **asset** (Sindh reforms) & a **liability** (capacity gaps).

Siddiqi (2012); Khan (2014).

TENSION 3

Customary Law vs. Statutory Equality

Jirga rulings, tribal compromise & feudal mediation contest Art. 25; persistent complications in women's inheritance, marriage & recovery strategies.

Khan & Khan (2013).

ANALYTICAL CONCLUSION

"Constitutional rights are aspirational until social infrastructure delivers them."

A coherent reading of the contemporary period requires a **three-tier evaluation**: (i) the extent to which constitutional articles are bound in court-tested practice; (ii) policy & commission capacity; and (iii) the enabling/disabling role of public attitudes, civil-society mobilisation, & media. Where all three align, progress is measurable (e.g. anti-honour killing reform). Where they diverge — or are actively contested — even well-drafted legislation can languish.

Contemporary Relevance

CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

Why These Issues Matter for the Class of 2026 & Beyond

LIVE DEBATES IN PUBLIC LIFE

1. Digital Platforms & Religious Hate Speech

Cyber-vigilante cases (2017 TLP riots & Blasphemy-related lynchings); proposed Digital Rights Act; courts weighing Art. 19 freedoms vs. Art. 245 security frameworks.

2. Sexual Harassment at Public Spaces & Workplaces

Protection Against Harassment of Women at Workplace Act (2010) re-energised; National Commission on the Status of Women tracked 1,500+ complaints (2022–23).

3. Transgender Inclusion

2018 Act implemented unevenly; digital ID conflicts with NADRA's 2017 gender-verification rules. Pakistan's gender-recognition system ranks among South Asia's most progressive.

4. Climate Change, Flood Aftermath & Vulnerable Communities

2022 floods displaced ~33 million; minorities & rural women disproportionately affected (UN Women, 2023); intersecting minority & gender vulnerabilities.

5. Enforced Disappearances & the Missing Persons Commission

A test of constitutional Due Process (Article 4) by judicial commissions; families across Balochistan & KP continue to litigate (Bouatta & Gayer, 2020).

PEDAGOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

- Critical reading of primary constitutional text.
- Evidence-based dissertation of contested statistics.
- Comparative regional framing (South Asia, Middle East).
- Civic literacy — translating knowledge into civic action.

LOOKING AHEAD

Provincial Reform Frontiers

- PECA amendment consultation (2023–24).
- KP, Balochistan DV bills active.
- National Commission for Minorities (2018 proposed, lapsed).
- Climate-vulnerability & gender budgeting.

Today's students will inherit a rights agenda shaped in this decade.

Summary of Key Points

SUMMARY

Distilling the Module — Six Integrated Takeaways

01

Constitutional Foundations

Pakistan's 1973 Constitution provides one of South Asia's most expansive bills of rights — Part II and beyond.

02

Minorities — Structural Vulnerability

3–4% of the population; protective frameworks exist on paper while implementation remains uneven.

03

Statutory Milestones

WPA 2006, Anti-Honour Killing 2016, Transgender Persons 2018, Domestic Violence laws — each addressing prior deficits.

04

Women's Achievements & Aspirations

Politics, judiciary, science, sports, literature, civil society — Pakistani women have led documented progress.

05

Implementation Deficit

Implementation gap is the crux — gaps remain in GBV enforcement, minority protection & economic participation.

06

Prospects — Critical Route Forward

Provincial innovation, judicial activism, civil-society momentum, & an organised student body can shape the trajectory.

SYNTHESISING STATEMENT

The contemporary state of Pakistani human rights is best understood as a continuum — a constitutional floor robustly drafted, a statutory fabric patched through decades of reform, and a lived reality still negotiating contested norms of culture, faith & power.

Conclusion

CONCLUSION

Pakistan's Human-Rights Future — Constructive, Cautious, Evidence-Based

I.

Constitutional Robustness

Pakistan's bill of rights is broad on paper — Articles 8–28 cover dignity, equality, religion, education, gender, & non-discrimination. The constitutional pathway for redress exists through High Court writ jurisdictions and Supreme Court PIL.

II.

Statutory & Institutional Acceleration

From 2006 onwards, a sustained legislative rhythm has translated constitutional ideals into protected categories. The persistence of NCSW, NCHR & provincial commissions provides an institutional infrastructure that previous decades lacked.

III.

Civic Capacity & Closing the Gap

The unresolved task is the implementation gap — bridging law & lived practice, the centrepiece of an agenda that future jurists, civil servants, scholars, & activists must collectively meet.

CLOSING REFLECTION

"A constitution, a society, and a person develop together — and the next chapter of Pakistan's human-rights story is being written today."

— Forum for Dignity & Rights, after Asma Jahangir (Annual Lecture Series, AGHS)

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